Westbrook Planning Board

~ Planning Board Meeting ~

Date: Tuesday, February 3, 2026
Time: 7:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1161616175
Packet: https://www.westbrookmaine.gov/AgendaCenter/ViewFile/Agenda/_02032026-983

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *Summarization necessarily condenses and selects; for complete context, nuance, and anything not covered here, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Unofficial summary. *This is produced by Westbrook Currents, an independent site — not the City of Westbrook — and may contain mistakes. For the official record, see the City's approved minutes and the meeting video.*

I. Roll Call

Roll Call & Officer Elections [0:25]

Discussion Summary

Chair Larry McWilliams called the meeting to order. Roll call: six of seven members present (McWilliams, Lucas Schrage, Kevin Price, Nancy Litrocapes, Jason Frazier, and Karen Axelson); Robin Tannenbaum and Vice Chair John Turcotte absent. Oriana Farnham arrived a few minutes later and was seated for all substantive votes. This was the board's first meeting of 2026, since no meeting was held in January.

With no meeting in January, the board held its election of 2026 officers. Larry McWilliams was re-elected Chair with no other nominations. John Turcotte, though absent, was nominated and elected Vice Chair.

Key Decisions

✓ Minutes of the November 24, 2025 meeting approved unanimously.

✓ Larry McWilliams re-elected Chair, unanimous.

✓ John Turcotte elected Vice Chair (in absentia), unanimous.

Action Items

None.

New Business

24-000166 — Site Plan — Watt Samaki Buddhist Temple and Asian American Cultural Center, Cumberland St. [4:31]

Discussion Summary

Craig Burris (Acorn Engineering, for the applicant) requested amending the phasing plan for a site plan approved August 6, 2024, to add a new Phase One: clearing roughly 9.2 acres of the ~30-acre parcel, installing erosion control, and removing stumps, ahead of later construction phases — intended to make the site more visible and walkable for prospective donors. The applicant requested the phase's timeframe be set at zero to six months rather than the originally proposed zero to three.

Chair McWilliams raised extended concerns about approving large-scale clearing before the project's funding is secured, suggesting the board consider requiring replacement tree plantings elsewhere in the city as a condition. Staff (Jenny Franceschi) explained the project is in an unusual position: because it already has a valid site plan approval, it must follow a more protective erosion-control process than clearing would otherwise require on undeveloped rural-zoned land, which needs no city permit at all. Member Oriana Farnham, arriving partway through, argued against adding conditions on fairness grounds (noting a golf course, cemetery, or single-family homeowner could clear the same land without any Planning Board review) and noted the funding challenges facing a minority-owned nonprofit in the current environment.

A temple board member explained the fundraising strategy: major donors familiar with comparable projects elsewhere often need to see a cleared, walkable site to commit funding, and the temple has secured enough to cover the clearing itself while pursuing additional road-construction financing. Member Jason Frazier confirmed erosion-control methods (silt fencing installed before clearing, concentrated around wetlands and streams) and later suggested a wildlife-friendly seed mix for post-clearing stabilization, which the applicant agreed to consider.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved unanimously by roll call, 7–0 (moved by Kevin Price, seconded by Karen Axelson) — amends the phasing plan's Phase One timeframe to zero–six months, incorporating conditions from the 2024 approval and the January 30, 2026 staff memo.

Action Items

None.

Workshop (No Votes)

26-000056 — Site Plan — 70 Scott Drive, Prompto Oil Change [30:10]

Discussion Summary

Barry Geyer (Jones & Beach Engineers), with Kevin King and Mike Harrison of Kay Brothers/Prompto 10 Minute Oil Change, presented a sketch plan for a 50′×50′ addition to an existing warehouse building plus expanded parking at the 1.74-acre Industrial Park District property. The building is used for warehousing and regional oil distribution (Kay Brothers supplies 26 Prompto locations, none currently in Westbrook); it is not an active oil-change retail site. The addition increases impervious coverage from 42.5% to 48.1% (under the 80% zoning maximum), mitigated by a planned rain garden. Board questions focused on oil-spill containment: Kevin King confirmed secondary containment around the storage tanks (roughly 3,000–4,000-gallon vertical tanks), a 110% EPA/DEP-required secondary containment standard under the facility's SPCC plan, and a third layer of containment within the warehouse.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — workshop item; feedback only, sketch-plan stage.

Action Items

None.

26-000067 — Land Use Ordinance Amendment — Child Care Definitions [35:53]

Discussion Summary

Assistant City Administrator Jenny Franceschi explained the amendment responds to recent state legislation: it raises the number of unrelated children a home-based provider can care for without state licensing (two to three, or four counting the provider's own children) and requires small-scale child care facilities be allowed as a permitted use in all residential zones, approved administratively by the zoning officer rather than coming before the board. City Planner Rebecca Spitella detailed the related terminology changes (matching state statute language) and added flexibility for play-area location and parking standards in limited cases; commercial-zone standards are unchanged.

Chair McWilliams raised extended questions about reduced oversight, since small home-based providers below the new licensing threshold require no license or city registration, making enforcement effectively complaint-driven only. Staff confirmed that's correct, framing a few children in a private home as comparable in impact to a large family's own children living there. No vote was requested tonight — this returns for formal board action later.

Discussion also touched on broader state housing/zoning mandate legislation from the prior session (minimum-density and reduced-parking mandates for sewered areas) that the City opposes outside its designated growth areas; staff planned to testify at a public hearing in Augusta the following week and offered to share bill numbers and talking points with interested board members.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — workshop/discussion item; returns for formal board action at a later meeting.

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was transcribed with AI-assisted speech-to-text and speaker identification. This process cross-checked names against the official Planning Board roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the Chair) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

Produced by Westbrook Currents — westbrookcurrents.com